

A three-day film appreciation workshop organised by the American Center for young cine buffs ensured an introspective analysis of Hollywood film genres. Susan M Shultz, Director, American Center, warmed up the atmosphere with an introduction on the Hollywood scene as it was and as it is. While Woody Allen's *Manhattan* stole the first day's first show, the second day was reserved for Arthur Penn's *Bonnie and Clyde*, the cult classic that redefined action in American cinema.

Speaking on comedy being serious, film editor Argha Kamal Mitra tossed up three basic ingredients - wit, common sense and humour - to describe the comic subtlety running through *Manhattan*. The characters become funny when you observe them from Woody's distance but they are not funny in themselves. Allen's comedy is not the banana skin variety. Looking in a different way, *Manhattan* is a sad film. "There is no self-indulgent camerawork here. You just listen to the story and follow the characters". So much so that the city becomes a character as much as the others. Seamless editing never allows the audience interest to flag and also ideally lets out a space to laugh in between dialogues, never tripping on the other. Gordon Lewis takes the credit for this brilliantly shot black and white film, which is photographically valid from the point of view of emotions being shown.

Stretching the structure and attributes of comedy a step further Gopalan Mullik, Professor, Department of Media and Film Studies, St Xavier's College picked up three comic scenes to

Forms and figures from Hollywood

A workshop on Hollywood genres gave young film buffs an insight into American cinema as it was and still is



Scenes from *Manhattan* and *Bonnie and Clyde*

drive home his point. Comedy made its appearance in the very first movie shot by Lumiere's. Comic anticipation is what makes the audience interested to know what is happening more than the comic action and this is what he called "Positioning the audience in a comic situation". A comic scene in the Lumiere's 1895 flick, *Rules of the Game* 1939, Shatranj Ki Khiladi 1978, played true to this idea of comic interpretation, according to Mullik.

Moinak Biswas of the Department of Film Studies, Jadavpur University spoke about the genesis of Hollywood, emerging on the global map vis-à-vis the generic filter that created a horizon of expectations. Action dominated Day Two. A screening of *Bonnie And Clyde* steered the course of the lecture. Subhajit Chatterjee, Fellow, Centre for the Study of Culture and Society, Bangalore said that action is not any particular genre, rather the idea is one of the conditions that

come to play in genres. Action foregrounds itself, constitutes a moment across various genres. *Bonnie and Clyde* unleashes a kind of violence where the confrontation between generations of alienated human beings, a characteristic of the 50's-60's, get pronounced by the film's jagged editing.

Taking a genre such as the Western, dating back to ES Porter's *The Great Train Robbery*, 1903, Chatterjee noticed an obsession with crime

articulating a generic tendency. Western narrative focus is constituted on law. White settlers trying to institutionalise law as against lawlessness, desert versus garden landscapes are the key to Western iconography. Till the return of the action films in the 70's intermediate genres, genre of the noir, detective films, auteur films held forte.

Starting off with cContemporary Hollywood, Madhuj Mukherjee of the Department of Media and Film Studies, gave a taste of action, image, music as seen in *Kill Bill* (Vol-1). "I love violence. If you don't, that means you don't like dancing", Tarantino had said once. This verbal effect is much translated on screen in *Kill Bill*.

The closing day had a talk by Somnath Zutshi, Seagull Arts and Media Resource Centre on pods, paranoia and 50's Hollywood sci-fi coupled with an interesting insight into sci-fi magazine induced genres by Abhijit Gupta of the Department of English, JU. The screening of Don Siegel's *Invasion of the Body Snatchers*, however, addressed this symbolic issue leading to various conflicting connotations.

— NEELANJANA GAUTAM